

S02-03 - The Ambush

Player text

Four figures rise from the brush in a clatter of breaking branches: ragged, wiry, armored in lashed river-stone and thorn. Their blades are mismatched, half of them salvaged. A fifth hangs back, sharper-eyed, clearly the one giving orders. They do not whoop or charge. They block the road, weapons up, like people who hate that it has come to this. "The cargo," the leader says. "Hand it over and you walk."

Public objective

Survive the ambush and protect the carriage and the package.

Raw source

- Id: S02-03
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-TWO
- Sectiontitle: Act Two: Cargo Reclaimers
- Title: The Ambush
- Shorttitle: The Ambush
- Order: 303
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png
- Alt: The Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers.
- Caption: The road ambush should feel dangerous and understandable at the same time.
- Mood: Cargo Reclaimers
- Gmgoal: Run the ambush as a dangerous moral choice: fight, defend, flee, surrender, or talk it down.
- Publicobjective: Survive the ambush and protect the carriage and the package.
- Readaloud: Four figures rise from the brush in a clatter of breaking branches: ragged, wiry, armored in lashed river-stone and thorn. Their blades are mismatched, half of them salvaged. A fifth hangs back, sharper-eyed, clearly the one giving orders. They do not whoop or charge. They block the road, weapons up, like people who hate that it has come to this. "The cargo," the leader says. "Hand it over and you walk."
- Gmnotes: The leader does not want a massacre. Use Back Off to create space and panic, not to punish parley. A downed ambusher can be spared without a roll; that lowers social difficulty.
- Gmscript: Say: "They want the cargo, not your lives. You can fight, defend the carriage, run, surrender the package, or talk while weapons are up. If you talk, make the case in character and roll Presence against Difficulty 15." If they ask who they are and the conversation earns it, have the leader say: "We're the Bramble Union. We didn't used to be thieves."
- Gmreadaloud: Four figures rise from the brush in a clatter of breaking branches: ragged, wiry, armored in lashed river-stone and thorn. A fifth hangs back, sharper-

eyed, clearly the one giving orders. "The cargo," the leader says. "Hand it over and you walk."

- Gmchecklist: Apply ambushAwareness from S02-02. Explicitly offer parley as a live action. Use Presence 15 for de-escalation; lower it for mercy, spared foes, or strong leverage. Record `bramble_outcome` using existing enum: killed, captured, spared, negotiated, escaped. Do not say Keystone Asset in player-facing text.
- Gmprivate: The self-name is earned through dialogue. The public/corporate label remains Cargo Reclaimers until that moment. Their salvaged gear points to former company people, but do not over-explain the hidden plot in combat. If players choose slaughter, they win the fight and lose the easiest route to the truth.
- Playertakeaway: You can win this with steel, restraint, surrender, or words, and the choice defines who the party is.
- Storytakeaway: The attackers are desperate people who want the cargo more than blood; their humanity is visible before their story is clear.
- Mechanictakeaway: This combat tracks an outcome, not a body count: Presence de-escalation, non-lethal choices, and `bramble_outcome` all matter.
- Rollcards: s02-03-talk-down-the-claimrunner S02-03 Talk down the claimrunner Talk down the claimrunner Presence Knowledge Presence Knowledge 15 Presence meets fear; Knowledge names the road claim. Violence becomes the only language if nobody offers another one. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. Violence becomes the only language if nobody offers another one. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it...
- Entityids: `bramble-union-ambusher` `bramble-union-claimrunner` `keystone-asset` `bramble-union` `bramble-union-villages` `bramble-stone-tumblers` `bramble-union-stoneweave` `the-wandering-briar` `bramble-ward-scrap-charm-cluster` `claimrunner-serrated-blade` `vial-of-briarpowder` `marlowe-fairwind` `reclaimer-personal-effects` `escort-carriage` `kazrak-industries` `hidden sealed-keystone-crate` `the-grail` `damage-armor` `hush` `fear`
- Entities: `bramble-union-ambusher` Bramble Union Ambusher enemy Enemy / Combatant `assets/icons/enemy.png` `assets/npc-images/bramble-union-ambusher/portrait_base.png` BRAM-bul YOO-nyun AM-boosh-er a road reclaimer who has never done this before, and it shows The frightened body in the bushes who makes the ambush real. Bramble Union Ambusher a desperate road reclaimer trying to stop the carriage without looking scared All borrowed bravado stretched thin over raw fear. They rehearsed the hard line and forgot everything after it. Under the moss and bark plates is someone who would much rather be home. Stop the carriage and survive the next minute. Stay back. I mean it. I do. a road reclaimer who has never done this before, and it shows `npc-profile-v1` NPC_System_Packet + image-informed hardening True Bramble Union Ambusher a road reclaimer who has never done this before, and it shows A mud-caked road reclaimer crouches under a patched hood, face half-swallowed by moss, bark plates,

rope knots, and scavenged ward charms. Bramble Union Ambusher: a road reclamer who has never done this before, and it shows Bramble Union Ambusher BRAM-bul YOO-nyun AM-boosh-er a road reclamer who has never done...

- Factionids: bramble-union
- Locationids: bramble-union-villages the-wandering-briar
- Itemids: bramble-union-stoneweave vial-of-briarpowder bramble-ward-scrap-charm-cluster claimrunner-serrated-blade
- Clueids: reclamer-personal-effects the-held-blow the-interrogation-answer
- Worldconnectionprompts: S02-03-bramble-union-world-connection bramble-union The Bramble Union You have been desperate enough to do something you are not proud of. What was it, and would you do it again to eat?
- Statecontrols: bramble_outcome Bramble outcome select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped Use negotiated for parley, spared for mercy after combat, captured for survivors held, escaped for routed or fled. ambushAwareness Ambush awareness select unresolved see-them-coming ambushed Controls opening position and first actor. brambleUnionNameLearned Self-name learned checkbox Check only after the leader says it in dialogue.
- Mechanicids: adversary-spotlight adversary-attacks damage-rolls evasion damage-thresholds armor-slots fear restrained disposition-track action-roll presence reaction-rolls hope stress help-an-ally gm-moves
- Playerquestions: What detail in Bramble Union Ambush tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real? What detail on a reclamer's gear makes them look like a craftsman from a hidden community rather than a disposable bandit?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in Bramble Union Ambush that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclamer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Choicesconsequences: Fight to kill The road clears, but survivors and truth routes close. S02-04 reveals only dropped gear and personal effects; location maps stay locked. Non-lethal force keeps dialogue possible. Parley Presence 15 can end or thin the fight. S02-04 can set bramble_truth_learned and unlock location maps. A failed parley still exposes reluctance and may reduce casualties if backed by mercy. Let them take the package The fight can end without blood, but the job breaks open. Act 3 begins from recovery, pursuit, or negotiation pressure rather than simple delivery. Defending the carriage keeps the contract intact but may cost lives. Spare a downed ambusher No roll; the leader sees mercy. Presence difficulty drops and S02-04 trust opens faster. Ignoring the wounded keeps the scene colder even if the party wins.
- Lootclues: Use Bramble Union Ambushers and Claimrunner loot tables Bramble Union Stoneweave: A garment of thousands of tiny polished stones moves like cloth and turns thorns like armor. Every fitted piece looks cut by hands that loved the work. Vial of Briarpowder: A small stoppered vial holds fine grey-green thorn powder that

seems to drink the light. A blade edge near it looks sharper and hungrier. Bramble Ward-Scrap Charm Cluster: A knot of blue ward shards, twine, and tiny salvage tags clacks softly at a Bramblefolk belt. It looks illegal only because it looks useful. Claimrunner Serrated Blade: A short serrated blade shows careful filing along the back edge and a handle wrapped in road cord. It is ugly in the practical way of a tool that has never had a decorative day.

- Handouts: Route sketch Guaranteed seed Guaranteed seed Earned seed
- Sources: S02-03-bramble-union-ambush
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_SCENE_UPGRADES.md
dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_MAPS_AND_COMBAT.md
dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_PER_CHARACTER.md
- References: Ambush battlefield #MAP-S02-03 Aftermath #S02-04 Hidden villages if mercy #MAP-LOC-bramble-union-villages
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED A spared/captured reclaimer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED Instinct: spot ambush. Presence: parley/interrogate...
- Livetools: encounter S02-03 MAP-S02-03 pages/combat/s02-03.html
- Percharacterlayer: garrick-reed Garrick Reed De-escalator Sees the leader's reluctance and knows this can end with words. Strong candidate for Presence 15 de-escalation; Affable and Hope can matter here. Garrick, she does not want this fight. Affable plus Hope might end it without a swing. Want to try? marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Custodian leverage As the one responsible for the package, she can speak to why it matters or bluff what handing it over costs. Can parley with leverage or use non-lethal control to protect the carriage. Marlowe, you know what you are carrying matters. Want to use that responsibility as leverage to talk them down? khari-nix Khari Nix Protect without killing Reads the fight as a line to hold, not a hunt to win. Can shield the carriage, protect allies, and subdue rather than slay. Khari, you can hold the line without putting anyone in the ground. Want to protect and subdue? barnacle Barnacle Disable or deal Sees which weapons, straps, or footing can be disabled without killing anyone. Can disarm, disable, or turn the standoff into a deal if parley starts. Barnacle, you could take them out of the fight without killing them, or cut a deal if this turns to talk...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway You can win this with steel, restraint, surrender, or words, and the choice defines who the party is. "Blade, bargain, shield, or surrender - all of those can end this. Pick the one your character can live with." "You can attack, protect the carriage, try Presence 15 to talk them down, spare a

downed attacker, run, or hand over the package and deal with the fallout." Make all exits real. The players should feel that victory is defined by consequences, not by eliminating every enemy. presence gm-moves fear stress Story takeaway The attackers are desperate people who want the cargo more than blood; their humanity is visible before their story is clear. "They look scared and committed, not gleeful. That does not make them safe. It makes them people." "If the leader speaks honestly, she can give the self-name: Bramble Union. If nobody earns that moment, keep them as Cargo Reclaimers or ambushers in player-facing language." This is the earned disclosure point. Use dialogue to reveal the name, never narration before the table creates the opening. presence gm-moves fear stress Mechanic takeaway This combat tracks an outcome, not a body count: Presence de-escalation...

- Playerbeats: S02-03-rise The rise The ambushers rise assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png The Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. text-first S02-03-choice The choice Fight, defend, or parley assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png The Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The road can become a fight, a standoff, a bargain, or a surrender. All of those are real choices. The road can become a fight, a standoff, a bargain, or a surrender. All of those are real choices. The road can become a fight, a standoff, a bargain, or a surrender. All of those are real choices. text-first S02-03-humanity The turn Their desperation shows assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png The Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Their armor is patched. Their blades are salvaged. Even as they threaten you, they look like people who have...
- Gmbeats: S02-03-rise The rise The ambushers rise Say: "They block the road and aim past you, toward the carriage. The demand is cargo, not blood." Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. The ambush begins with a demand, not a charge. Opening position depends on ambushAwareness from S02-02. Players understand the objective pressure. Player takeaway Players understand the objective pressure. "They block the road and aim past you, toward the carriage. The demand is cargo, not blood." "The playable facts are: Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies." Use this beat to point the table at one immediate choice. The player-facing fact is: Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. reaction-rolls gm-moves Story takeaway The ambush begins with a demand, not a charge. "They block the road and aim past you, toward the carriage. The demand is cargo, not blood." "The story fact you can trust is: The ambush begins with a demand, not a charge." This beat changes the...
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 9000
- Playersafeprojection: S02-03 scene The Ambush assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png The Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The road ambush should feel dangerous and understandable at the same time. Cargo Reclaimers Survive the ambush and protect the carriage and the package. Four figures rise from the brush in a

clatter of breaking branches: ragged, wiry, armored in lashed river-stone and thorn. Their blades are mismatched, half of them salvaged. A fifth hangs back, sharper-eyed, clearly the one giving orders. They do not whoop or charge. They block the road, weapons up, like people who hate that it has come to this. "The cargo," the leader says. "Hand it over and you walk." S02-03-rise The rise The ambushers rise assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png The Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. Ragged figures in stone-and-thorn armor block the road. Their weapons are up, but their demand is for cargo, not bodies. text-first S02-03-choice The...

- Companionmaps: MAP-S02-03 MAP-LOC-bramble-union-villages MAP-LOC-the-wandering-briar
- Slidenumber: 35
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-ADVERSARY adversary-turns adversary-turns M15 S02-03 high mandatory scene-enter Spotlight the Threat Danger moves when the rules give you the spotlight. Daggerheart does not use fixed initiative. When Fear, failure, or a stat block feature gives you the spotlight, choose the active adversary and make its move. Spend Fear only for a real pressure beat: extra adversary spotlight, Fear feature, adversary Experience, or a stronger GM move. Adversary turns wiki/mechanic/adversary-turns teach-by-example True Keep combat procedures crisp without turning the scene into initiative bookkeeping. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True SPOT-M-HELP help-an-ally help-an-ally M8 S02-03 high mandatory first-use Help an Ally Team support is a live move. Spend 1 Hope to Help an Ally. Roll a d6 and add it to the ally's roll. If more than one PC helps, add only the highest helper die and narrate the strongest boost. Help an Ally wiki/mechanic/help-an-ally in-scene-prompts Wake up team economy in the first hard group pressure scene. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True SPOT-C-KHARI-EARLY khari-nix Khari Nix early S02-03 high optional scene-enter Khari, Move to the Front Guardian...
- Spotlightsummary: 2 1

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